Operation Badr, is likely to have taken out the earlier plan, brushed it up and fine-tuned it with his close confidants. 'There are indications that the plan (employing jehadis) was approved as early as October 1998 by Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif, when it was proposed to him by General Musharraf'.[3] It is believed that this core group, headed by Musharraf, included Lieutenant Generals Mohammad Aziz Khan, the chief of general staff, and Mahmud Ahmed, general officer commanding (GOC) 10 Corps, and Major General Javed Hasan, the force commander northern areas (FCNA). The plan was kept secret from both the air force and naval chiefs and also all other corps commanders. Key elements of the ISI would have been in the need-to-know loop. My understanding of this episode is that a generalized scenario employing *mujahideen* or so-called 'freedom fighters' might have been articulated to get the nod of the prime minister, without going into details or specifying that the Pakistan Army soldiers and officers would be undertaking this operation across the LoC.

Therefore, in my perception, to cloak this suicidal venture in a shroud of secrecy, a great fraud was committed by General Musharraf and his inner coterie on not only the people of Pakistan but also on the Pakistan Army. This is particularly so in the case of the gallant soldiers of the NLI and the simple people of Gilgit, Hunza, Skardu and others from the Northern Area. The truth began to emerge within a few weeks, when the battle was joined by the Indians. Despite denials by Pakistan, it did not take long for the world to become aware as to who was right, and who had committed the aggression.

The Indian military response was slow and measured, massive and ruthless, notwithstanding the hiccups in the beginning. While ensuring that we didn't create a strategic imbalance elsewhere along the western border, the Indian Army retaliated with everything that was necessary and could be put into the battle to recapture the heights of Kargil. Additional forces, including infantry formations, artillery, air defence, army aviation and other combat support and